UESTC 3010: Team Design Project & Skills

Lecture 2: Teamwork

Lecture Objectives

- Why teamwork?
- What are the characteristics of an effective team
- The roles of team members
- To understand stages of team development
- To identify and practise the skills that enable members of a team to work together successfully

What some people say . . .

I did all the work on my teams

If I didn't do the work, it didn't get done

I never trusted anyone else to do the work

No one did work as well as I wanted it done

Everyone looked to me to do the work

Why TEAM work?

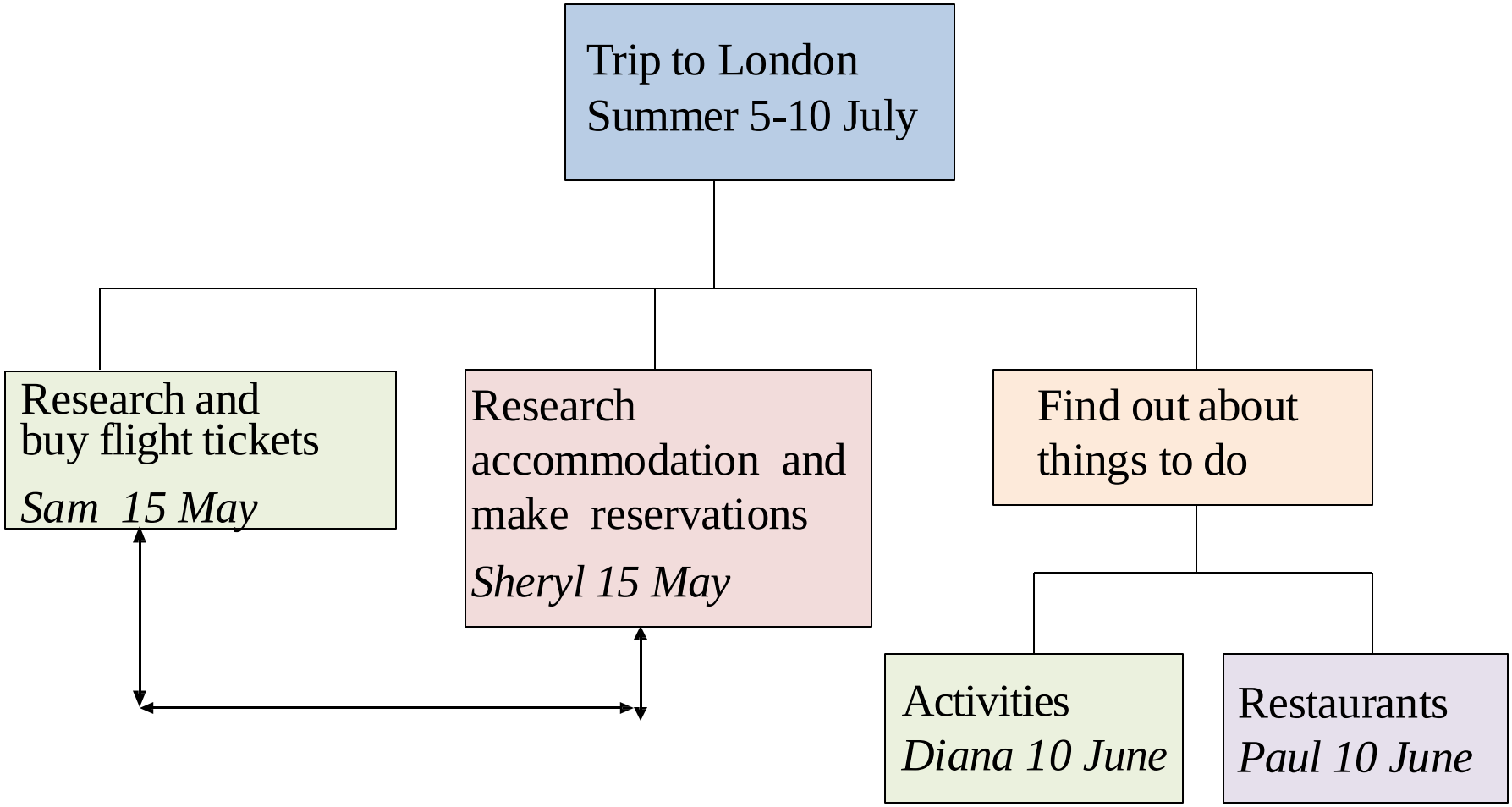
Projects require diverse skills, this creates a need for group (team) work

TEAM: Together Everyone Achieves More

Innovation is simply group intelligence having fun.

Tom Peters

Example of team work to plan a vacation



What is a Team?

"A team is not a bunch of people with job titles, but a congregation of individuals, each of whom has a role which is understood by other members. Members of a team seek out certain roles and they perform most effectively in the ones that are most natural to them".

– Dr Raymond . M. Belbin

What is a Team?

"A team is a small number of people with complementary skills who are committed to a common purpose, performance goals, and approach for which they hold themselves mutually accountable."

– (Katzenbach and Smith, The Wisdom of Teams, Harper Collins, New York, 1994)

What makes an Effective Team?

- Good Communication & Social Skills - face-to-face and other modes of communication to monitor progress
- Positive Interdependence: “We” instead of “me”. Members succeed only if all succeed
- Individual Accountability/ Personal Responsibility
- Shared goals - the members have negotiated shared aims and goals

What makes an Effective Team?

- Group Processing - all members are supported to contribute equally to the workload
- Mutual trust: members listen to each other, respect contributions, help each other to clarify ideas, and show interest in each other
- Processes for Conflict Resolution
- Mutual interest: members focus on the interests of the group as a whole, and avoid personalizing problems or differences of opinion

Assigning a leader/Coordinator

- **Why?**

  If everyone is responsible, no one is
- The leader/coordinator should
  - Focus the team toward the task
  - Get all team members to participate
  - Keep the team on deadline
  - Suggest alternatives
  - Help team members confront problems
  - Summarize team decisions

Setting Ground Rules

- Goals and expectations
- Work norms
- Facilitator norms
- Communication norms
- Meeting norms
- Consideration norms

Meeting Guidelines

- Use an agenda! If you don’t have one at the beginning of the meeting, make one
- Small talk is O.K. at the beginning of the meeting, then get down to business
- Do mid-meeting check in
- End with next steps clearly articulated
- See Project Team Productivity Tools

Communication Behaviours to Observe

- Who participates
- Who doesn't
- How do people take turns?
- Who talks to whom?
- Who responds to whom?
- How are interruptions handled?
- Is silence O.K.?
- Is anyone dominating the conversation?
- How are decisions made?
  - By consensus?
  - By voting?
  - By one person?

Team Destroyers

- Individual behaviours
- Group behaviours

Individual Behaviors

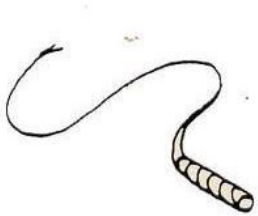
- “Ego integrity”
- Self-interest versus group interest
- Inability to observe self and/or use feedback
- Different styles of
  - Learning
  - Interaction
  - Expression

Group Behaviors

- Defensive routines
- Reluctance to test assumptions
- Getting “off task”
- Lack of boundaries
  - Poorly defined roles
  - Unclear objectives and/or expectations

Common Problems in Teams

Hogging—talking too much



Flogging—beating an issue to death

Frogging—jumping from topic to topic

Bogging—getting stuck on an issue

Dead buffaloes—tiptoeing around a contentious issue

Handling Difficult Behavior

- If a team member is
  - Talkative
  - Quiet
  - Argumentative or complains a lot
  - A free rider
- Try the following
  - Using the two-minute rule
  - Asking the person a question
  - Being explicit about your responses and reactions
  - Talking through norms at the beginning

Handling Group Problems

- If the group is
  - Foundering
  - Digressing
  - Deciding too quickly
  - Being indecisive
  - Feuding
- Try the following
  - Use an agenda
  - Use the “parking lot”
  - Use a facilitator
  - Use a voting plan
  - Address the problem or go to a third party

Stages of Team Development

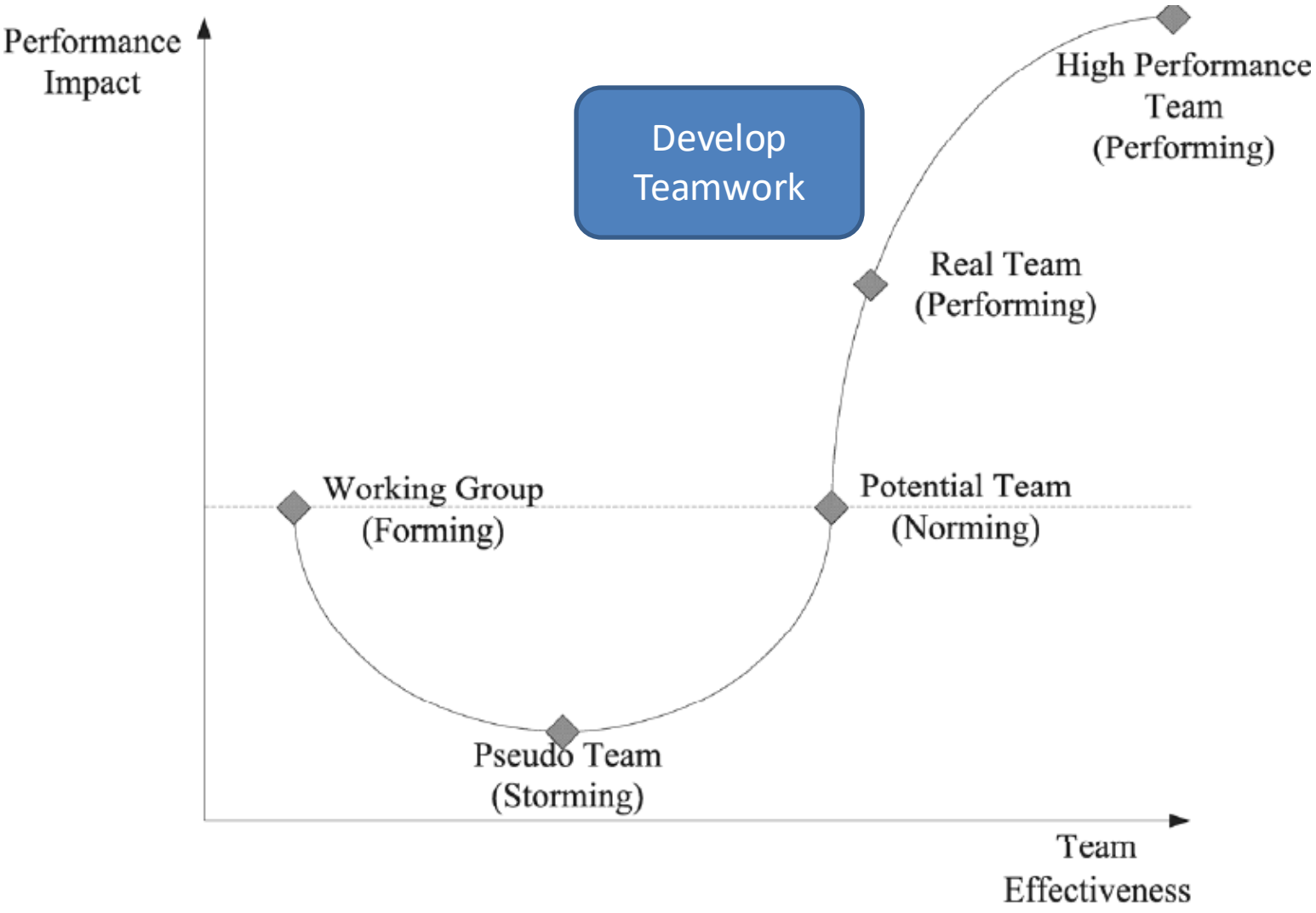
Social psychologist Bruce Tuckerman noted **four** key stages:

- **Forming:** group members get to know each other, establishing guidelines, goals and processes, assessing and breaking down the task at hand
- **Storming:** individuals assert themselves and develop preferences, with arguments or disagreements potentially arising about how to proceed

Stages of Team Development

- **Norming:** work begins in a more organized and coordinated manner, rules and processes are established and progress is made
- **Performing:** the team as a whole focuses entirely on the task and its completion
- *NB: Group work is a process → find ways to progress to the **'performing'** stage as quickly as possible. How long a stage lasts depends on how long the group is together and the nature of the task. Teams are dynamic, not a fixed entity.*

Team Performance Curve



Stage 1 - Forming a Team

- People feel uncomfortable when they first join a team or group.

- How is this shown and what can we do about it?

- How can we move on from this and help people unite and work together?

Choosing a Project Manager

- Clear cut leader - point of resolution
- Often sets and articulates goals and strategy
- Responsible for workload assignment
- Spots problems early
- Leads through difficulty in fair and productive way
- Merits respect through ability rather than demands through position

Types of Project Manager

- Traditional
- Passive
- Facilitative

Traditional Project Manager

- Directive and controlling (“bossy”)
- No questions—just do it!
- Sole decision maker
- Nontrusting
- Ignores input
- Autocratic

Passive

- Has a hands-off approach.!
- Gives too much freedom.!
- Does not guide or direct.!
- Provides extreme empowerment.!
- Uninvolved!
- Figurehead!

Facilitative

- Creates an open environment.
- Encourages suggestions.
- Provides guidance.
- Welcomes creativity.
- Considers all ideas.
- Maintains focus on the group vision.

Tasks of the Project Manager

- Organises team meetings.
- Monitors team progress.
- Helps coordinate the individual tasks.
- Helps resolve conflicts.
- Dependable
- Honest
- Informs group of problems BEFORE they occur
- Efficient communicator
- Committed to doing the job properly

Tasks of the Project Manager

- Hopefully leadership is shared by most of the team
- Somebody has to be responsible for each and every aspect of the project
- Talent to do the job (as opposed to talk/pretend)

Stage 2 - Storming

- Be aware that conflict may emerge between sub groups or over leadership.
- There may be tension in the team because of some disagreement/dislike between members.
- Members may be reluctant to continue and so fail to reappear after a break (fight or flight)

Stage 3 - Norming

- A sense of team identity develops along with trust.
- Team members begin to share ideas and objectives.
- They agree on what is to be achieved and commitment develops.

4 - Performing

- Energy is now directed towards the task.
- It needs to be channelled and coordinated well
- Vigilance re team processes is important
- Give credit where it is due
- Remember the introduction of any new members returns the team to the “forming” stage

Building a Team

How to help your team:

- get acquainted and feel comfortable with their fellow members
- develop ground rules and norms for the team
- communicate and work cooperatively
- facilitate the sharing of information and expectations between members
- begin trusting each other
- Other??

Roles of Team Members

- Clarity at the start helps to reduce friction- roles/ shared goals/conflict resolution…
- Allows people to get credit for their achievements
- Clear responsibility and timelines for tasks avoids undue last minute pressure
- Roles need to be shared where possible to avoid boredom and assist in retention

Real Team Characteristics

1. Select Team Members Based Upon Skills.
2. Identify and Agree Upon Objectives

3. Make it Clear How the Team will Make Decisions!
4. Hold effective meetings.
5. Determine team roles.
6. Assign tasks & responsibilities.
7. Spend a lot of time together.
8. Respect team members.
9. Manage conflicts constructively.

Factors Critical for Strong Teams

- Team Goals
- Team Structure
- Roles within Teams
- Timelines for Teamwork

Basic Team Skills

The following features are fundamental to good teamwork:

- ✓ **trust:** making sure you meet all commitments and maintain confidentiality when required
- ✓ **coaching:** using your skills, knowledge and experience to assist others or ask for help
- ✓ **sharing information:** to assist others do their job
- ✓ **flexibility:** show a willingness to cooperate and help others when possible
- ✓ **good manners:** doing small, simple things, eg. thanking colleagues for their help

Team Communication

Teams need to master 3 types of communications:

- ✓ The team members need to communicate well with *each other*. They rely on each other's work; they are each other's *internal customers*
- ✓ The team needs to communicate well with other teams at work. These are also *internal customers*
- ✓ The team has to communicate directly with their *external customers.*

Communication Behaviours

- ✓ Assertiveness
- ✓ Listening Responsively
- ✓ Speaking Confidently
- ✓ Contributing to Decisions

Communication Choices

- **Aggressive** is characterised by anger, blame and insensitivity to others.
- **Dominating** is bossy and puts people's backs up.
- **Passive** lets others trample all over you.
- **Restrained** may be inoffensive but does not fully take part in a team.

- **Assertive** *is* ***the one in the middle, the one to aim for in communicating with people in your team****.*

Assertiveness

- ✓ Communicates clearly and honestly.
- ✓ Expects that s/he has as much right as anyone else in the team to be heard.
- ✓ Can say ‘no’ .
- ✓ Respects and listens to others.
- ✓ Admits to errors without feeling s/he has lost face.
- ✓ Knows s/he deserves respect
- ✓ Gives the same rights to others as s/he claims for her/ himself

Listening Responsively

Listening is part of assertive behaviour: ·

- **Aggressive**: always talks·
- **Assertive**: listens and talks appropriately·
- **Passive**: always listens

How can you use questions to check that you have understood?

Speaking Confidently

- ✓ Team members contribute with honesty and integrity even though they disagree.
- ✓ Be assertive - but consider what you say may be crucial **or** may be wrong.
- ✓ ‘Play the ball but not the person’ - disagree with an idea not the person who thought of it.
- ✓ Acknowledge other people’s ideas and contributions and build on them.
- ✓ Speak with enthusiasm not emotion.

Conflict Resolution

- Because of an inability to resolve conflict the team may splinter and sub-groups may form.
- Anticipate conflict, know why it arises and have personal and team strategies to deal with it.
- Importance of protocols to manage conflict and other problems

Establish some Rules

- **Communication processes**
  - Exchange contact details, establish rules and
  - limits on communication forms (email, text message, mobile, Facebook)

- **Decision making processes**
  - How will decisions be made? By consensus?
  - What will you do if there is an even split of preferences?

Establish some Rules and Good Practices

- **Task analysis and distribution of workload:**
  - Be wary of dividing up questions into even portions, going off to work individually to return the day before the task is due to put it all together. This approach rarely works well.
  - Think creatively about how different group members might work together on separate tasks, and how roles might be distributed among the group according to individual strengths.
  - Above all, be sure that workloads are evenly distributed. Monitor the workload as a group. Some of the tasks may require more work than first assumed.

Establish some Rules and Good Practices

- **Meeting schedule:**
  - Be clear from the start how often you will meet, and decide on the purpose of the meetings.
  - Record meetings in a log - very important for keeping on track and not forgetting things

Establish some Rules and Good Practices

- **Feedback**:
  - Good, constructive feedback is difficult to give; but it is essential for smooth and productive (and confidence building)
  - Start by focusing on the positives – what was well put, well argued, a good idea or a useful point
  - Then you can point out faults or flaws, but tactfully, and without assuming that you have all the answers
  - End with something positive
  - Effective feedback is specific rather than general. Likewise, offering an alternative is far more constructive than simply disagreeing.